

SD #10 - The Shotgun

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Who actually loses voters when you require proof of citizenship

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Classification: Open Source Intelligence **Topic:** SAVE Act partisan impact — documentation barriers, fear suppression, and 2026 competitive race analysis
Source confidence: Primary sources verified. Census ACS, CPS microdata, academic peer-reviewed evidence, bill text, Federal Register citations. Adversarial review and 125-agent swarm simulation cross-validated. **Issue:** SD #10

Executive Summary

Kansas tested documentary proof-of-citizenship (DPOC) requirements for voter registration from 2013 to 2018. Over 19 years, state officials found at most 39 noncitizens who managed to register. The law blocked 31,000 eligible citizens. **800 citizens harmed per noncitizen caught.**

The SAVE Act (H.R. 22) proposes to take that model national. SD #9 examined the pipeline — how voter registration data already flows into DHS immigration enforcement systems regardless of whether the bill passes. This piece examines what that pipeline does to the electorate.

I built three new data adapters for this analysis: Census Bureau American Community Survey (ACS) for citizenship demographics by congressional district, the Current Population Survey (CPS) Voting Supplement for turnout by citizenship status, and MIT Election Lab historical results for before/after analysis. The dataset covers 440 congressional districts, **99,063** CPS microdata records, and election returns from 2000-2024.

The conventional wisdom — that DPOC requirements suppress Democratic voters and benefit Republicans — is half the story. I assess **60-65%** probability the net effect favors Republicans. Not the 80-20 most commentators assume.

The documentation barrier is a shotgun, not a scalpel. Both coalitions bleed. **13%** of Independents, **10%** of Democrats, and **7%** of Republicans lack ready access to citizenship documents. Eight of ten congressional districts with the lowest passport rates are represented by Republicans, concentrated in the rural South. **62%** of adults in evangelical hubs lack valid passports. In 2024, naturalized citizens split 51-47 Harris over Trump — an 18-point swing from 59-38 Biden in 2020. The assumed partisan asymmetry has weakened substantially.

But the fear channel — the behavioral suppression driven by connecting voter registration to immigration enforcement — is directional. It concentrates in naturalized citizen communities, mixed-status households, and neighborhoods where ICE enforcement has been visible. The documentation barrier cuts both ways. The fear does not.

A swarm simulation of 125 agents debating this question for 48 rounds reached the conventional conclusion. The data I collected says the picture is more ambiguous, and that ambiguity is the analytical contribution of this piece.

Methodology

This analysis rests on three purpose-built data adapters, seven statistical models, a 48-round swarm simulation, and adversarial review.

Data collection. I built a Census Bureau ACS adapter querying the 2023 5-year estimates — citizenship status by congressional district (B05003 tables), citizen voting-age population (B29001), nativity cross-tabulated with education and poverty. A CPS Voting Supplement adapter pulling the November 2024 post-election survey — 99,063 microdata records with turnout by citizenship status, demographics, and registration barrier codes. An elections adapter sourcing MIT Election Data + Science Lab results for historical before/after analysis in states that implemented proof-of-citizenship requirements.

Statistical analysis. Seven quantitative models: district exposure index across 437 CDs, partisan impact simulation across 20 party-composition scenarios, CPS barrier code analysis, state-level turnout gap mapping, Arizona Prop 200 before/after comparison, race-specific competitive district exposure, and education-poverty intersection scoring.

Swarm simulation. MiroFish engine: 125 agents derived from a knowledge graph of the raw intelligence, 48 rounds of simulated social interaction across Twitter and Reddit platforms, 1,179 total actions. The agents received the data without a thesis and formed their own conclusions.

Adversarial review. Adversarial review identified three channels the primary synthesis underweighted. A separate adversarial review stress-tested the SAVE Act passage probability, revising from 3% to 7% after accounting for filibuster reform scenarios.¹

The Documentation Gap

The Center for Democracy and Civic Engagement (CDCE) / Brennan Center survey (2023, n=2,386) established the headline: **9.1%** of voting-age American citizens — **21.3 million** people — lack ready access to any citizenship document. **3.8 million** lack documents entirely.

The partisan breakdown is where I want to spend time.

13% of Independents lack ready access. **10%** of Democrats. **7%** of Republicans. At the extremes: **4%** of Independents have no citizenship documents at all, versus **2%** of Democrats and **1%** of Republicans. The gap between parties is real — Democrats are more exposed than Republicans by 3 percentage points. But Independents are the most exposed group, and in 2026 they break anti-Trump.

The geographic data contradicts the national narrative further. The National Redistricting Foundation found that all ten congressional districts with the lowest passport possession rates are in the South. Eight of ten are represented by Republicans. Nine of the ten districts with the highest passport rates are held by Democrats — six in California, plus Massachusetts, New York, and Virginia. Passport application fees start at **\$165**, creating a financial barrier that tracks with income, geography, and party affiliation in exactly the inverse direction most commentators assume.

62% of adults in evangelical hubs lack valid passports. **58%** of working-class adults. **53%** of rural middle Americans. These are core Republican constituencies facing documentation barriers that DPOC requirements would activate.

I ran an exposure index across all 437 congressional districts using ACS 5-year estimates. The national mean naturalized citizen share of the voting-age population is **12.1%**, median **10.4%**, standard deviation 7.4 percentage points. **226 districts** (51.7%) exceed 10% naturalized share. **86 districts** (19.7%) exceed 20%.

The top districts are overwhelmingly safe Democratic seats: NY-6 (32.0%), FL-26 (31.9%), CA-17 (31.3%). The bottom districts are overwhelmingly safe Republican seats: KY-5 (1.2%), WV-1 (1.3%), OH-2 (1.4%). The naturalized citizen channel concentrates in places where elections are not competitive. This is a structural feature of the data, not a coincidence — immigrant communities cluster in urban areas that are already electorally decided.

The Partisan Impact Model

I modeled the net partisan suppression effect across 20 scenarios varying party composition and Independent lean. Inputs: CDCE documentation gap rates (D=10%, R=7%, I=13%), assumed 50% effective suppression (accounting for document acquisition and non-voter baseline), 500,000 CVAP per competitive CD.²

The result: **Democrats net-lose more voters in every single scenario tested.**

The range runs from **+1,650** (in a high-Independent, R-leaning-Independent scenario) to **+5,670** (in a D-heavy composition with D-leaning Independents). The mean across all 20 combinations: **+3,822** net Democratic voter loss per competitive CD.

This is not a subtle effect. In a district decided by 10,000 votes, a mean suppression of 3,822 net Democratic voters shifts the margin by 3.8 percentage points. In a district decided by 5,000 votes, it is potentially decisive.

But the uncertainty is massive. Legion’s adversarial review identified two channels the base model underweights:

The re-verification channel. The SAVE Act does not grandfather existing registrations. Any address change, name change, or party switch triggers re-verification. USPS reports 27 million address changes annually. Across 435 districts over a two-year cycle, that yields roughly **80,690** re-verification triggers per CD. Assuming 65% of movers are registered voters and applying the 9.1% CDCE documentation gap rate with 50% adaptation: $80,690 \times 0.65 \times 0.091 \times 0.50 = \sim \mathbf{2,387}$ voters lost per CD through this channel alone — and that uses the overall CDCE rate, not the higher rates for younger and more mobile populations. Movers skew younger, more urban, more minority — Democratic-leaning.

The native-born documentation burden. In New Hampshire — the only state with both a competitive federal race and active DPOC law — **23,749** native-born citizens face documentation barriers at the 2.1% CDCE rate, versus only **2,344** naturalized citizens at 2.9%. The native-born channel is 10x larger. In WI-3, where the 2024 margin was under 12,000 votes, the native-born documentation burden alone (**12,238** citizens) approaches the margin.

My revised central estimate: **3,000-5,000** net Democratic voter loss per competitive CD, with uncertainty bounds of **500-8,000**.³

The Fear Channel

The SAVE Act does not merely add a documentation requirement. It creates a structural link between voter registration and immigration enforcement.

Section 8(j)(5)(D) mandates that DHS “shall conduct an investigation to determine whether to initiate removal proceedings” when voter verification identifies a noncitizen. The data flow is statutory: register to vote → state submits to DHS SAVE database → DHS cross-references enforcement databases (ATS, TECS, SEVIS, Numident) → if flagged, DHS investigates for deportation. No data firewall. No restrictions on secondary use.

This matters because the system’s error rates are documented and high. Denton County, Texas: 12 of 84 flagged voters proved citizenship — a **14%** minimum false positive rate. Moore County: 6 of 11 flagged were eligible citizens — **55%**. St. Louis County: 691 initially flagged, revised to 133 after corrections — an **81%** reduction. When the base rate of the condition you are screening for (noncitizen voters) is near zero, even modest false positive rates guarantee that the overwhelming majority of people flagged are citizens.

For **10.6 million** U.S. citizens who share a household with an undocumented immigrant, this creates a rational calculation: registering to vote puts their data into the system being used to find and deport their family members.⁴

A KFF/New York Times survey (2025, n=1,805) found that **31%** of naturalized citizens now fear detention or deportation of themselves or family members — up from **12%** in 2023. **21%** have limited outdoor activities or government interactions since January 2025.

Amuedo-Dorantes and Lopez (2017, *Demography*) found immigration enforcement reduces voter registration propensity by **5%** among citizens in mixed-status households — but does not reduce turnout among those already registered. The effect is on system entry. The same study found that lower registration was accompanied by greater civic volunteering — suggesting selective avoidance of government-facing systems, not political apathy.

The compound effect in 2026 is structurally unique: the administration doubling ICE's workforce to 22,000+ (from ~10,000), rescinding the sensitive locations policy for schools and churches, expanding the SAVE database to include all citizens, DOJ demanding voter rolls from 44+ states, and DHS investigating naturalized citizens for pre-naturalization voting. No prior election cycle has combined all five.

I assess the fear channel represents a third suppression mechanism, distinct from documentation barriers (mechanical) and re-verification burden (bureaucratic). Citizens who possess every required document choose not to engage with a government system connected to immigration enforcement. This channel is not addressable through document assistance programs. It operates independently of whether citizens possess the required documents.⁵

Historical Precedent

Three states have tested documentary proof-of-citizenship requirements. Each tells a different part of the story.

Kansas (2013-2018). Secretary of State Kris Kobach implemented DPOC for voter registration. Over 19 years, state officials found at most 39 noncitizens who managed to register. The law blocked 31,000 eligible citizens. **Ratio: 800 citizens harmed per noncitizen caught.** A federal judge struck the law down under the National Voter Registration Act (NVRA) and 14th Amendment and ordered Kobach to complete continuing legal education courses.⁶

The Kansas data cuts both ways. The 800:1 ratio is the strongest evidence against DPOC as a policy tool. But Sharice Davids won KS-3 with 53.6% in 2018 — the first Democrat to win a Kansas House seat in a decade — during the Kobach regime. Mobilization backlash offset suppression in at least one competitive race. I assess **40-50%** probability that backlash fully offsets suppression in at least one competitive race nationally, but only **15-25%** that it offsets across all competitive races.

Arizona (2004-present). Proposition 200 required proof of citizenship for voter registration. Over 30,000 registration applications were rejected — 17% of rejected applicants were Latino. The Supreme Court ruled 7-2 in 2013 (*Arizona v. Inter*

Tribal Council) that DPOC was preempted by the NVRA for federal registration forms. Arizona maintains a bifurcated system: DPOC for state and local elections, not for federal.

Arizona also produced SB 1070 (2010), which triggered massive Latino mobilization — permanent early voter list enrollment tripled from 90,000 to over 300,000. The dual effects illustrate the mobilization-suppression paradox: enforcement can simultaneously energize organized communities and suppress isolated individuals. Both are real. They operate on different populations.

Georgia (database verification). Georgia used the DHS SAVE database to cross-reference voter registrations without requiring physical documents at the point of registration. It caught 1,634 noncitizen registration attempts. None voted. The system worked without creating a documentation barrier for eligible citizens. Georgia is 100% REAL ID compliant — every resident with a state license has already proved citizenship to the Department of Driver Services.

Georgia's model demonstrates that noncitizen registration can be caught through database verification without the suppressive effects of documentary proof requirements. The SAVE Act does not follow Georgia's model. It requires both.

The academic evidence on voter ID impact is contested. The GAO (2014) found turnout declined 1.9-3.2 percentage points in Kansas and Tennessee relative to comparison states. The NBER (Cantoni & Pons, 2019) found no statistically significant effect across 1.6 billion observations. I assess both are valid for their scope — GAO measured immediate impact before adaptation, NBER captured longer-run equilibrium — but neither studied DPOC specifically. Photo voter ID is less burdensome than documentary proof of citizenship.

Swarm Simulation: Where 125 Agents Diverge

I ran a MiroFish swarm simulation to test whether independent agents would reach the same conclusions as my analytical team. The setup: 125 agents derived from a knowledge graph built from the raw intelligence (data only, no thesis), 48 rounds of simulated social interaction, 1,179 total actions across simulated Twitter and Reddit platforms.

The swarm reached the conventional conclusion. DPOC requirements disproportionately impact Democratic and minority voters, with projected turnout declines of 5-8% for Latino voters, 3-5% for Asian voters, and 2-3% for Black voters. The swarm estimated a 1-2 percentage point Democratic vote share reduction in competitive districts.

My data-driven analysis diverges. The swarm did not weight three findings that reshape the picture:

First, the swarm treats naturalized citizens as a Democratic bloc. The 2024 data shows an 18-point swing: 51-47 Harris over Trump, compared to 59-38 Biden over Trump in 2020. White naturalized citizens went 55% Trump. Hispanic naturalized citizens went 51% Trump. The assumed partisan asymmetry has weakened substantially.

Second, the swarm does not separate the native-born documentation channel from the naturalized citizen channel. In the tightest House races — WI-3 (margin under 12,000), IA-1 (margin under 800) — naturalized citizen concentration is low (3.1% and 5.2% respectively). The documentation burden that actually matters in these races falls on native-born citizens who lack passports and birth certificates. That channel cross-cuts partisan lines.

Third, the swarm underweights the Republican-side documentation burden. Eight of ten lowest-passport districts are Republican-held. Evangelical, working-class, and rural populations face passport poverty at rates comparable to or exceeding minority populations. The swarm's framing — minority suppression equals Democratic suppression — misses half the shotgun blast.

The probability divergence is the analytical contribution. The swarm implies ~75-80% probability of net Republican benefit. I assess 60-65%. The **15 percentage point** gap reflects data the conventional narrative does not incorporate.

Competitive Race Overlay

House races by naturalized citizen exposure:

The districts where DPOC has the largest naturalized citizen impact are not the tightest races. CA-45 (25.6% naturalized, estimated 11,894 affected voters) and GA-7 (23.6%, 9,389 affected) are competitive but not razor-thin. NC-12 (14.3%, 4,633) and AZ-1 (11.9%, 4,312) face moderate exposure.

The paradox: WI-3 and IA-1 — the tightest margins in the country — have the lowest naturalized citizen exposure (3.0% and 5.2%). DPOC barely registers through the naturalized citizen channel in the races where a small number of votes would be decisive.

But Legion's correction matters here. WI-3 has 582,776 native-born citizens. At the 2.1% CDCE rate, **12,238** face documentation friction — in a district decided by fewer than 12,000 votes. The native-born documentation burden, not the naturalized citizen burden, is what makes DPOC relevant in the tightest races. And that burden falls on both parties.

Senate races by statewide naturalized citizen concentration:

At a 2 percentage point additional DPOC suppression scenario, the competitive state voter impact is material against recent margins:

- **Georgia:** 1,091,821 naturalized citizens. 21,836 voters lost at 2pp — documentation suppression alone does not flip a statewide race. But the fear channel in GA's mixed-status households (estimated 40,000-70,000 at risk) exceeds the 2020 presidential margin of 11,779.
- **Arizona:** 892,963 naturalized citizens. 17,859 voters lost at 2pp — similarly insufficient alone. But fear-based suppression (50,000-80,000 at risk) exceeds the 2020 presidential margin of 10,457.
- **New Hampshire:** 80,811 naturalized citizens. Small DPOC impact. But HB 1569 is live, with 44,000 same-day registration voters needing physical

documents at the polls. The trial outcome — ruling expected before September — is the binary event.

The NH nexus is the only state where active DPOC law intersects with a competitive federal race for 2026. I assess **40%** probability HB 1569 survives its trial and remains in effect for November.

Probability Assessment

Carried from SD #9:

Assessment: Federal SAVE Act becomes law before November 2026 - Current: **7%** - Basis: 60-vote Senate threshold, nine votes short. Talking filibuster reform and must-pass vehicle attachment viable but Thune explicitly opposes, three named holdouts irrevocable. - Resolution: H.R. 22 signed into law by November 3, 2026

Assessment: NH HB 1569 in effect for November 2026 election - Current: **40%** (unchanged from SD #9) — more likely it does not survive than it does - Basis: Trial concluded, ruling pending. Kansas/Arizona precedents favor plaintiffs but current judiciary more conservative. No injunction — law currently in effect. - Resolution: Law not enjoined by November 2026 general election

Assessment: Republicans retain House majority after 2026 midterms - Current: **15%** - Basis: Trump 39% approval, D+5.3 generic ballot, 220-215 majority. Historical avg 36 seat loss at 40-45% approval; the only president below 40% (Bush 43 at 38%) lost 30 seats. - Resolution: 218+ Republican seats certified by January 3, 2027

Assessment: DPOC laws enacted in 3+ additional states by end 2026 - Current: **55%** - Basis: FL signed (2027), SD/UT pending, MI ballot initiative, 15 states with active bills. - Resolution: Three or more states beyond NH, WY, LA enact DPOC by December 31, 2026

New for SD #10:

New assessment: Net partisan effect of DPOC requirements favors Republicans in competitive 2026 races - Initial: **62%** - Basis: CDCE rate differential (D 10% vs R 7%), Independent suppression (13% rate, anti-Trump lean), fear channel concentrates in D-leaning demographics. Tempered by Republican documentation burden (passport poverty in 8/10 lowest-rate CDs), 2024 naturalized citizen realignment (51-47), and native-born channel cross-cutting in tightest races. Adversarial review confirmed 60-65% range. - Resolution: Post-election analysis of turnout patterns in DPOC vs non-DPOC states, controlling for national environment. Assessable by March 2027.

New assessment: SAVE Act-equivalent documentation barriers suppress more than 100,000 eligible voters nationally in 2026 cycle - Initial: **45%** — more likely not to happen than to happen; the evidence is indirect - Basis: Per-CD model yields 3,000-5,000 net loss per competitive CD across ~30 competitive districts. Total range: 90,000-150,000. But only NH has active DPOC for federal races in 2026 —

the 100K figure requires counting the fear channel and DOJ voter roll effects operating without enacted legislation. - Resolution: CPS November 2026 supplement compared to 2024 baseline. Assessable by mid-2027.

I trade this. Full track record and methodology at signaldsp.substack.com.

Escalation/Resolution Signals

NH HB 1569 ruling. The single highest-impact binary event. Ruling expected before September 2026 primary. Upholding creates the test case and accelerates state adoption. Blocking removes the only competitive-state implementation.

DOJ voter roll litigation outcomes. DOJ has demanded voter rolls from 44+ states and threatened legal action against those that refused; at least 24 states and D.C. have resisted. Court rulings on these disputes will determine whether the voter-roll-to-enforcement pipeline has legal backing.

Naturalized citizen registration rates in H1 2026. If state-level registration data shows declining naturalized citizen registration in DPOC states versus non-DPOC states, that is a direct signal of the chilling effect operating in real time. The 9.7pp existing turnout gap is the baseline.

State DPOC bill movement. South Dakota and Utah could enact before 2026 midterms. Florida takes effect 2027. Each new state provides implementation data and expands the evidence base.

ICE enforcement near registration infrastructure. Reports of enforcement actions near voter registration offices, DMVs, or government buildings where registration occurs would amplify the fear channel. The rescission of sensitive locations policy removed the formal barrier.

What This Means

The SAVE Act is a shotgun aimed at a problem that barely exists. Kansas proved the ratio: 800 eligible citizens blocked per noncitizen caught. Georgia proved the alternative: database verification that catches noncitizen registration attempts without blocking eligible citizens.

The conventional wisdom that DPOC requirements are a partisan weapon aimed at Democrats is half the story. The documentation barrier hits Republican constituencies — evangelical, rural, working-class, elderly — at rates the conventional narrative does not account for. The 2024 naturalized citizen realignment (51-47 Harris, down from 59-38 Biden) further erodes the assumed asymmetry.

But the fear channel IS directional. Connecting voter registration to immigration enforcement databases — whether through the SAVE Act or through the executive pipeline already operational — creates behavioral suppression concentrated in

communities with proximity to enforcement risk. That suppression cannot be offset by document assistance programs because it operates on citizens who already possess every required document.

I assess **60-65%** probability the net effect favors Republicans in competitive 2026 races. The uncertainty is genuine: the bounds on per-district suppression run from 500 to 8,000 voters, and mobilization backlash has a **40-50%** probability of fully offsetting suppression in at least one competitive race.

The federal SAVE Act will not pass. I assess **7%**. The state-level picture is where this story lands: New Hampshire's HB 1569 is live, the trial is concluded, and Judge Elliott's ruling will set the precedent. That ruling is the single highest-impact event for DPOC and 2026.

The data is here. The methodology is transparent. Track the probabilities, and hold me to them.

Sources

- Census ACS 5-Year 2023: citizenship by CD (B05003, B05003A-I), CVAP (B29001), nativity × education (B06009), nativity × poverty (B06012)
 - CPS Voting Supplement November 2024: 99,063 microdata records, citizenship turnout, registration barriers (PES3)
 - MIT Election Data + Science Lab: House returns 1976-2018, county presidential 2000-2016, Senate 1976-2018
 - CDCE/Brennan Center/SSRS survey (2023, n=2,386)
 - National Redistricting Foundation: passport possession by congressional district
 - KFF/New York Times survey (2025, n=1,805): naturalized citizen fear
 - FWD.us: mixed-status household estimates (ACS 2021)
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 - H.R. 22 bill text: GovTrack, 119th Congress
 - DHS SORN: Federal Register, 90 Fed. Reg. 48948 (October 31, 2025)
 - DHS confirmation of voter data sharing: Democracy Docket (September 11, 2025)
 - DOJ voter roll demands: AP (September 9, 2025), Stateline (September 12, 2025)
 - Kansas: *Fish v. Kobach*, 10th Circuit
 - Arizona: *Arizona v. Inter Tribal Council of Arizona*, 570 U.S. 1 (2013)
 - Georgia citizenship audit: Georgia Secretary of State
 - SAVE database errors: ProPublica/Texas Tribune (February 2026)
 - NH HB 1569 trial: NH Bulletin, Democracy Docket case tracker
 - MiroFish simulation: 125 agents, 48 rounds, project sd-9-save-act (simulation run during SD #9 research, data carried forward)
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Methodology: Calibration & Resolution Criteria

Track Record: View all resolved predictions and Brier scores at signaldispatch.substack.com/track-record

Disclosure: I trade prediction markets on this analysis. Positions disclosed when relevant.

Signal Dispatch combines structured OSINT data feeds with analytical synthesis. The data behind this analysis — Census queries, CPS microdata, statistical models, swarm simulation logs — is available in the research archive.